

PREPARATORY ACTIVITY WATCH

Ukraine: Preparatory Activity Watch

21-23 February 2022 | Information available by 23:59Z, 23 February | replay

Analytic state: Escalation | AnCR: Low | Change: Rapid increase in anomaly energy and domain breadth

Keys: Russia; Ukraine; Moscow; Ukrainian border; Yelnya; Klinty; Belgorod; Valuyki; Boguchar; Millerovo; Dzhankoi

VIIRS NTL 2022-02-21-2022-02-23: not yet available (3-day reconstructed latency).

Assessment

We assess it is almost certain that abnormal activity is present across several Russian observables with bearing on Ukraine.

Russian financial conditions (CBR, Moscow), public reporting on Russia and Ukraine and maritime warnings are simultaneously elevated relative to their recent baselines. The signal is co-movement across those channels.

We assess it is likely that the abnormality has intensified: anomaly energy and domain breadth have increased.

It is a realistic possibility that this reflects heightened readiness or reversible preparation. It is unlikely to be routine variation.

The decision this supports is urgent collection against independent physical and official-posture sources on those AOIs.

Why this is on the watchlist

Indicator	Observation	Analytic significance
Russian financial conditions	CBR funding spread reached 1.66 sigma on 22 Feb after 1.05 sigma on 21 Feb	Elevated relative to the recent baseline.
Public reporting	GDELT reporting remained elevated; Wikipedia attention rose from 375,181 to 763,132 views	Confirms a heightened information environment; partly dependent on the same public reporting.
Physical activity	FIRMS recorded 2 thermal detections within the monitored staging AOIs on 23 Feb.	Large deviation from the recent baseline.
Maritime warnings	NAVAREA warnings declined from 18 to 7	Does not reinforce the broader anomaly.

GDELT, ICEWS and Wikipedia share a public-reporting substrate.

Competing explanations

Likelihoods use the PHIA Probability Yardstick.

Hypothesis	Likelihood	What would discriminate
Routine variation	Unlikely	Anomalies decay without additional domains activating.
Exercise / demonstration	Unlikely	Physical activity consistent with announced exercise patterns.
Defensive readiness	Realistic possibility	Persistent posture indicators without further domain broadening.
Reversible preparation	Realistic possibility	Additional independent logistical, financial or spatial indicators.
Preparation for overt action	Realistic possibility	Sustained multi-domain increase plus corroborating physical or official-posture evidence.
Measurement artefact	Highly unlikely	Anomalies disappear after source or baseline validation.

Collection requirements

1. Physical posture - highest priority. The anomaly is strongest in financial, infrastructure and information indicators. Independent physical evidence on Yelnya, Klinty, Belgorod, Valuyki, Boguchar, Millerovo and Dzhankoi would discriminate. VIIRS NTL not yet available at this cutoff.

2. Official posture. Collect contemporaneous Russian, Ukrainian, UK, US and relevant allied official statements and formal measures, including travel advice, diplomatic drawdowns, defence announcements, NOTAM/NAVAREA restrictions and sanctions measures. Identify changes in declared threat assessment or costly government action.

3. Information-environment composition. Current data establish increased volume and attention, not tone, narrative concentration or source diversity.

Analyst note

Analytical confidence is low. The information base is incomplete: independent physical reporting is not yet available; official-posture collection is missing; public-reporting series share a substrate. The key uncertainty is whether the cross-domain anomaly is a temporary response to the existing crisis environment or the early observable consequences of material preparation.